

RENAISSANCE SPLENDOUR

This was the period when fashion finally moved from draped clothing to fitted garments and the art of tailoring came into its own. Clothes gained structure and became stiffer and more supportive. The first templates for garments that remained modern items of clothing were created: hose with a fitted doublet and outer coat for men, a bodice with a separate skirt for women.

Differentiation in clothing

Clothing now consisted of a greater number of parts including detachable sleeves, under- and overskirts, sleeveless jerkins, and breeches of different lengths. This emphasis on separate parts of the body reflected the new interest in human anatomy that had gripped the natural sciences. The masculine form was enhanced by the latest clothing, with its wide shoulders, prominent codpieces, strong legs, and bellies. Women's clothes emphasized their narrow waists, combining wide shoulders and skirts with a deeply pointed bodice. The garments of different nations or regions showed greater differentiation, and the religious schism between the Catholic church and the reform or Protestant faiths led to the creation of new visual identities for members of the different faiths.

Age of exploration

The Ottoman Empire rose in the near East and south-eastern Europe, after conquering Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul) in 1453, bringing Islamic might to the region. Through the 16th century the Spanish empire was the richest and most powerful; it began to wane in the early 17th century as the French became more dominant. This was an age of conquests, exploration, and expansion into the Americas, following Columbus's arrival in 1492. Other explorers ventured around the world opening up sea-trading routes around Africa and Asia, crossing the Pacific and discovering new goods to bring back to Europe.

Dominant personalities

New realism and naturalism in painting meant that portraits were much more realistic and could accurately represent individuals and their clothes. Dominant personalities in Europe – Henry VIII and Elizabeth I in England, Philip II in Spain, François I and Henry IV in France, the de'Medici dynasty in Florence, and Suleiman the Magnificent in the Ottoman empire – reinforced their position with strong visuals in paintings that portrayed them in fashionable clothes. Ruffs, in particular, became popular. The starching process stiffened cloth and allowed the development of very wide ruffs, and lace became the most luxurious textile to own. In the late 16th century heeled shoes were invented.



1450–69



▲ Young man wearing fur

1450s

Sable, lynx and other exotic furs become fashionable, replacing squirrel furs such as miniver and vair. Ermine remains the prerogative of royalty.

1450s

Women's hair is pulled back from forehead and covered by a caul (small bag worn over a bun at the back of the head) or a crespine (mesh net). Fashionable women shave their foreheads and eyebrows. In warmer Italy married women wear their hair long, braided, in loose knots, and uncovered.

1450s

Brocade becomes a luxury fabric as weaving techniques improve. The best fabric comes from Italy with Chinese, Indian, and Persian motifs reflecting increased trade with these countries.

◀ Italian brocade dress

1470–99

1470s

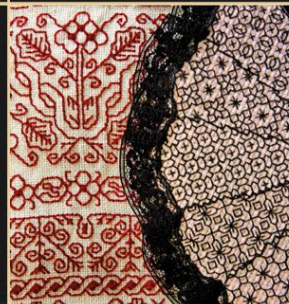
Early versions of the farthingale appear in Spain as the *verdugada* or *verdugado*, a bell-shaped skirt stiffened with hoops of cane, or later, willow. Originally hoops are worn on the outer surface of the dress, later they go underneath the overskirt.

1476

The new fashion is for slashing garments to reveal the lining or undergarments. Perhaps from the actions of Swiss soldiers following Battle of Grandson in 1476, when they patched tattered clothes with fabrics plundered from dead nobles.

1480s

Men start to wear their hair longer. Blonde hair becomes the vogue in Italy for women. Women sit in the sun with their hair spread out on circular disc-shaped hats to lighten it. Chemicals are also used to bleach it.



1490s

Metal pins cost a penny each in Henry VIII's time so fish bones and thorns are often used for sewing.

1500–19

1500–1560s

Men begin layering clothes to give bulk and width, especially at the shoulders, creating a square outline. They start wearing hose to show off their shapely legs, suggesting athleticism.



▲ Wide, square shoulders

1509

Marriage of Catherine of Aragon to Henry VIII of England starts a trend for geometric blackwork embroidery on linen clothing. Designs are inspired by patterns popular in Spain from Moorish culture.

◀ Blackwork embroidery

1516

Charles V of Spain unites the Hapsburg territories with Aragon and Castile. Spain becomes the dominant power in Europe. Black clothes with rich decoration are favoured.